

UBS 201 HISTORY AND THEORIES OF COMMUNITY PLANNING GROUP 7 FOREST HILL SOUTH

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QUICK FACTS

Neighbourhood: Forest Hill South
(City of Toronto #101)

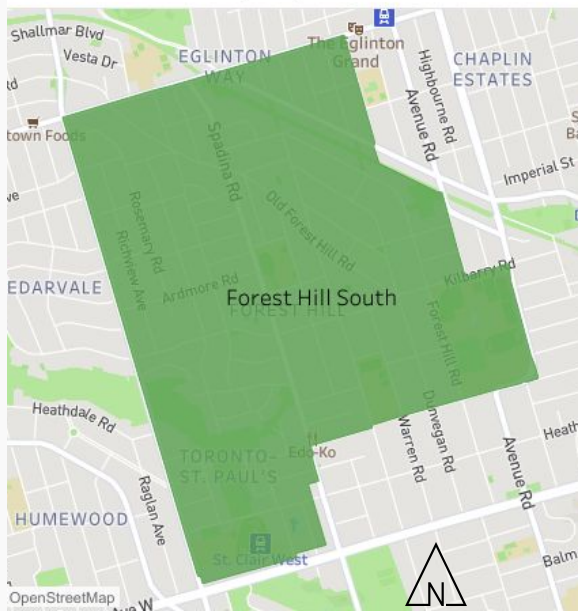
Boundaries:
North: Eglinton Avenue West
South: St. Clair Avenue West / Nordheimer Ravine
East: Spadina Road / Avenue Road corridor
West: Bathurst Street

Population (2021): ~10,860 (City of Toronto)

Housing profile (2021): Majority single-family houses; ~70% detached/semi-detached

Land area: ~1.6 km²; density ~6,800 people/km²

Forest Hill South (101)



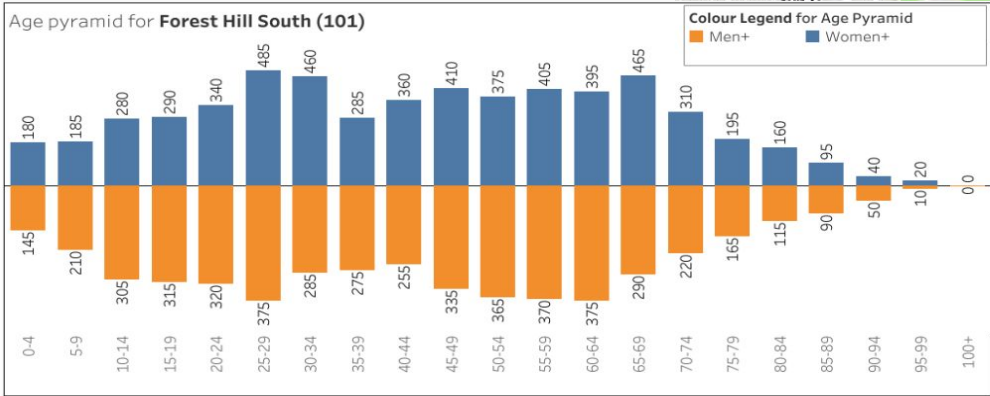
Snapshot for Forest Hill South (101)	
Population, 2016	10,732

Population change (%), previous 5 year period	-1.78%
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Population density per square kilometre, 2016	4,380
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Population by Age		
Mean age	Toronto	40.6
	Neighbourhood	41.0
Median age	Toronto	39.3
	Neighbourhood	41.0

Population by Age and Gender*		
Mean age	Men+	40
	Women+	43
Median age	Men+	39
	Women+	43



Women+	54.0%
Men+	46.0%

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

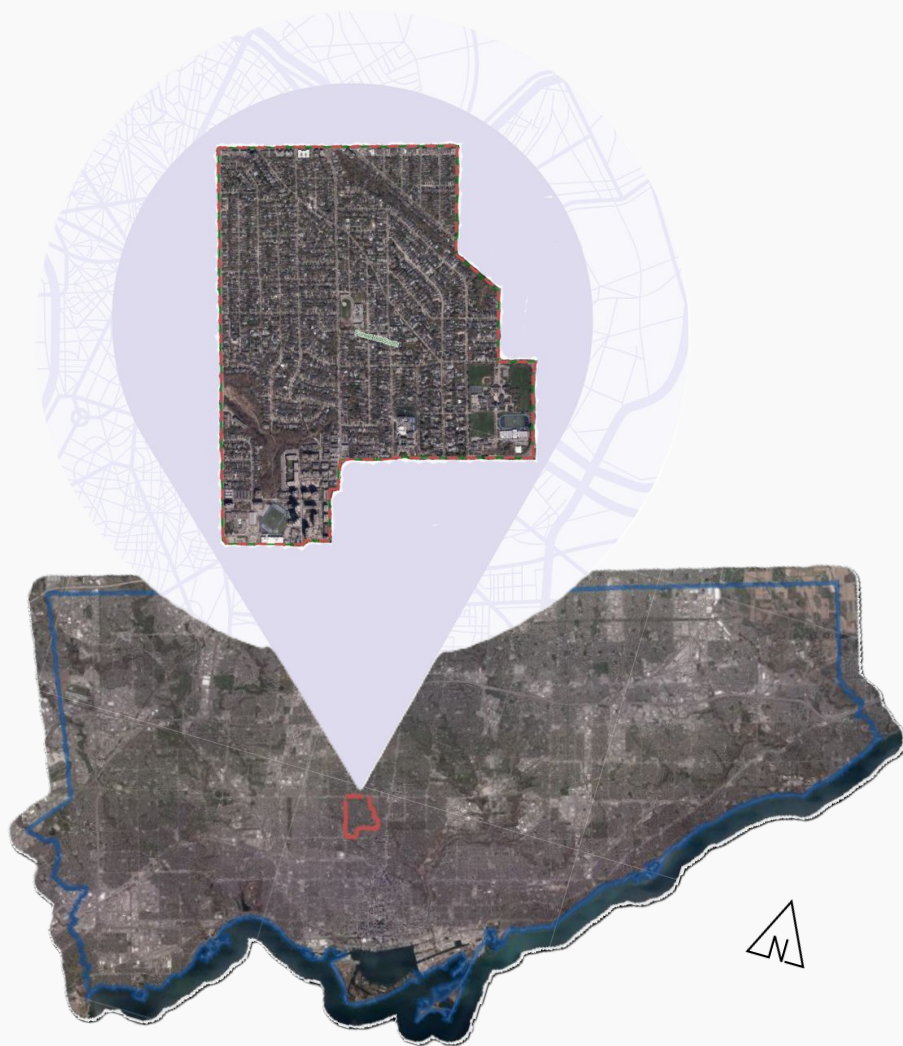
Where is Forest Hill South?

Forest Hill South is located in midtown Toronto, south of Eglinton Avenue and north of St. Clair Avenue. It is one of the highest-income neighbourhoods in Canada. Historically it was physically and socially separated from industrial zones to the south and west, and the street layout forms a “green enclave” with curving streets and limited through connections.

Forest Hill became its own village on January 1, 1924, after being officially approved in late 1923. Back then, the area was called Spadina Heights. Residents wanted better schools and felt they weren't getting good value for their taxes, so they asked the Ontario government to let them separate from Toronto.

The village was surrounded by:

- Toronto to the south and east
- York Township to the north and west

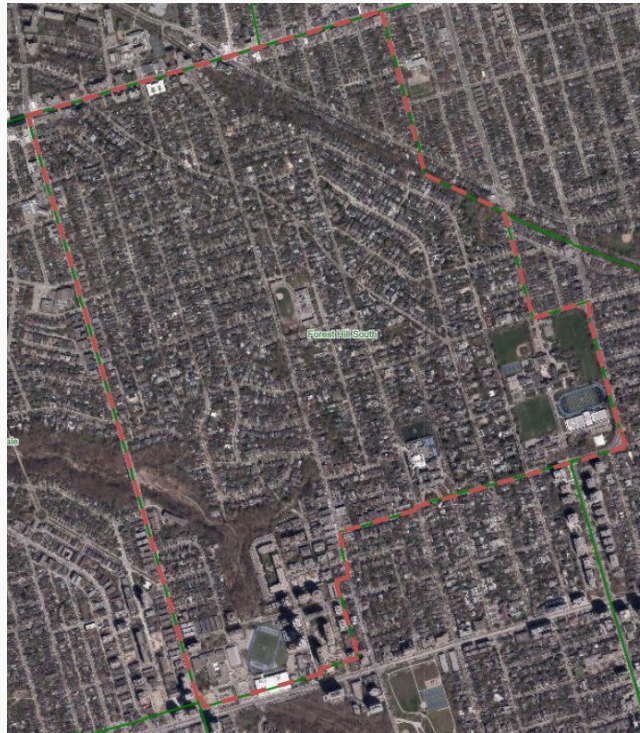


PLANNING THEORIES: FOREST HILL SOUTH

1939



2024



When was Forest Hill planned?

- Developed mainly in the 1920s–1930s, before modernist planning took hold Independent village (1923–1967) with its own bylaws and council
- Inspired by Garden City ideals: curving streets, greenery, and quiet residential character
- Follows Neighbourhood Unit design: schools and places of worship at the center, shops on the edges
- Opposite of modernist high-rise cities low-rise, English-style, suburban refuge



ELEMENT 1:

LOT SIZE & CONFIGURATION

Forest Hill South features a mix of single-family homes and large apartment buildings with lot sizes varying from typical residential plots, to the larger land areas required for new multi-unit developments. The configuration includes a range of housing sizes, from small apartments to four or more bedroom houses.

Lot sizes

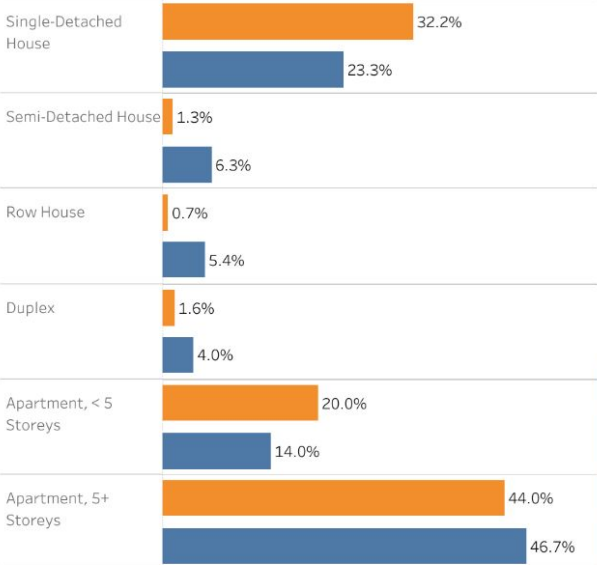
Residential lot: An example of a single residential lot is approximately 8.93 m x 9.48 m (29.4 ft x 31.1 ft), with a total lot size of about 16.3 m x 62.5 m (53.5 ft x 205 ft).

Large-scale development lots: The minimum size requirement for major developments is 10,000 square meters.

Apartment building lots: The size of the land used for newer, large-scale developments like the South Forest Hill Residences project is sufficient to build a large residential complex with over 600 units.

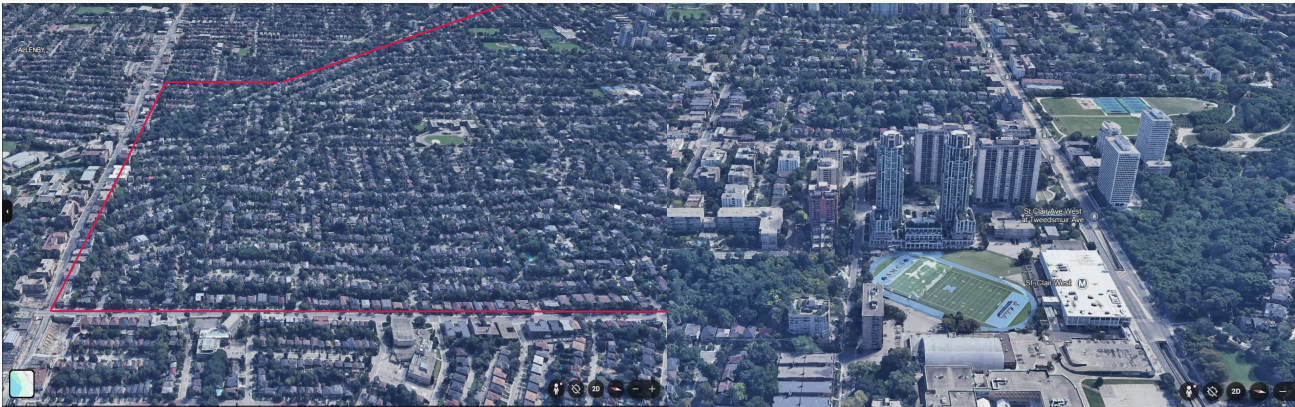
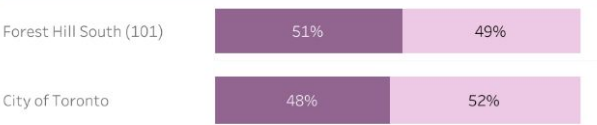
Total Private Dwellings: 5,075

Private dwellings by structure type



Households by tenure for Forest Hill South (101)

Renter households	Owner households
2,610	2,470



ELEMENT 2:

ARRANGEMENT OF LAND USE

Residential Dominance

According to the 2021 City of Toronto Neighbourhood Profile, the majority of dwellings ($\approx 70\%$) remain single-detached or semi-detached houses.

Condominium apartments and mid-rise buildings now appear mainly along Spadina Road, Eglinton Avenue West, and near Bathurst Street

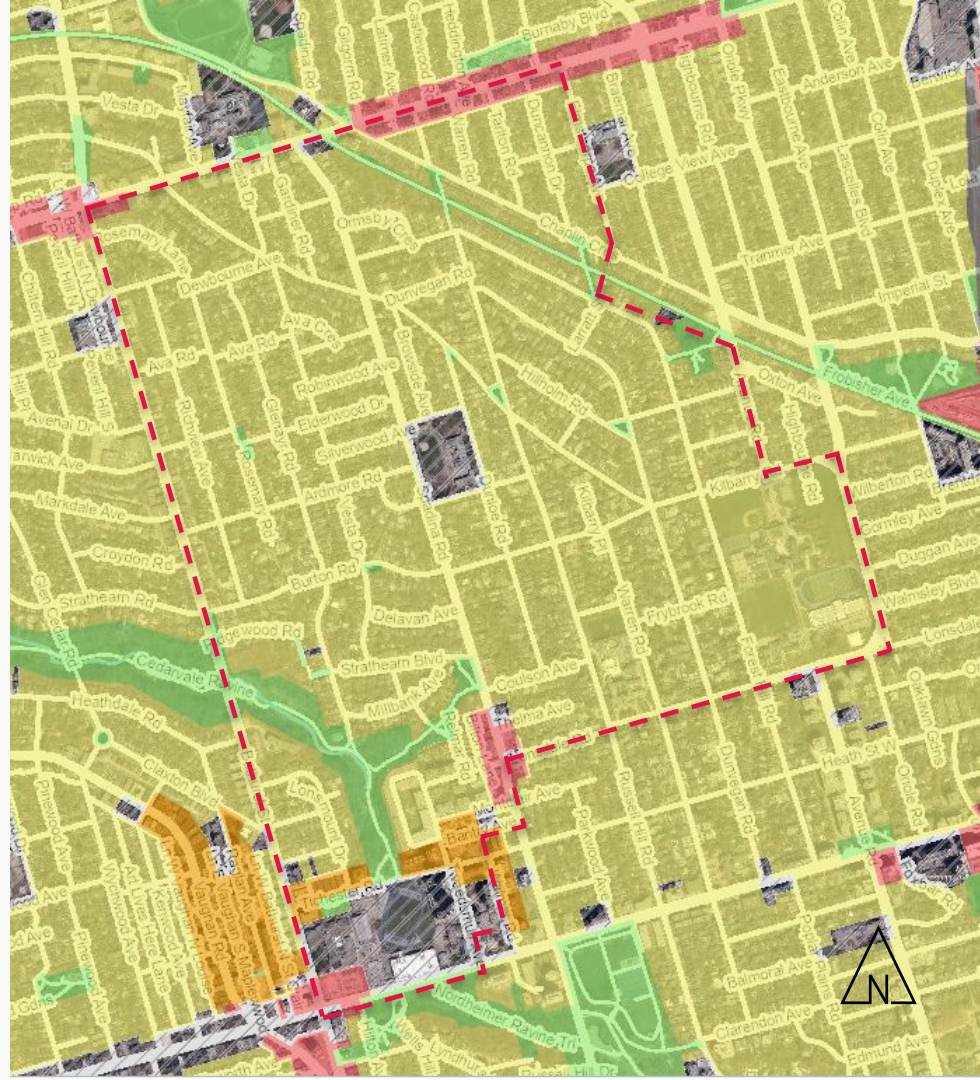
Commercial Uses

Forest Hill Village (Lonsdale & Spadina Road) serves as the primary mixed-use hub with boutique retail, cafés, small-scale offices
Eglinton Avenue West forms a secondary commercial corridor, historically automobile-oriented, now being redeveloped with Eglinton Crosstown LRT

Institutional & Open Space

Educational and community institutions e.g., Bishop Strachan School, Upper Canada College, Grace Church on the Hill, Holy Rosary Church occupy significant land parcels, maintaining the neighbourhood's historic institutional core.

Green space remains primarily privately landscaped, with few public parks inside Forest Hill South itself; nearby Cedarvale Ravine and Nordheimer Ravine act as its open-space edges.



ELEMENT 3: TRANSPORTATION

Historical context: Major roads (Spadina Rd., Bathurst St., Eglinton Ave) already in place; prior to heavy transit investment the area was automobile and bus-oriented.

Key routes: Spadina Rd (north–south), Eglinton Ave W (east–west), Bathurst St (western boundary). TTC bus routes 33 (Forest Hill), 32/312 Eglinton connections; St. Clair streetcar and nearby subway nodes.

Rapid transit: The Eglinton Crosstown (Line 5) project crosses Eglinton and affects transit access — project status has been delayed with updates through 2024–2025

Eglinton Crosstown LRT Project



33 Forest Hill

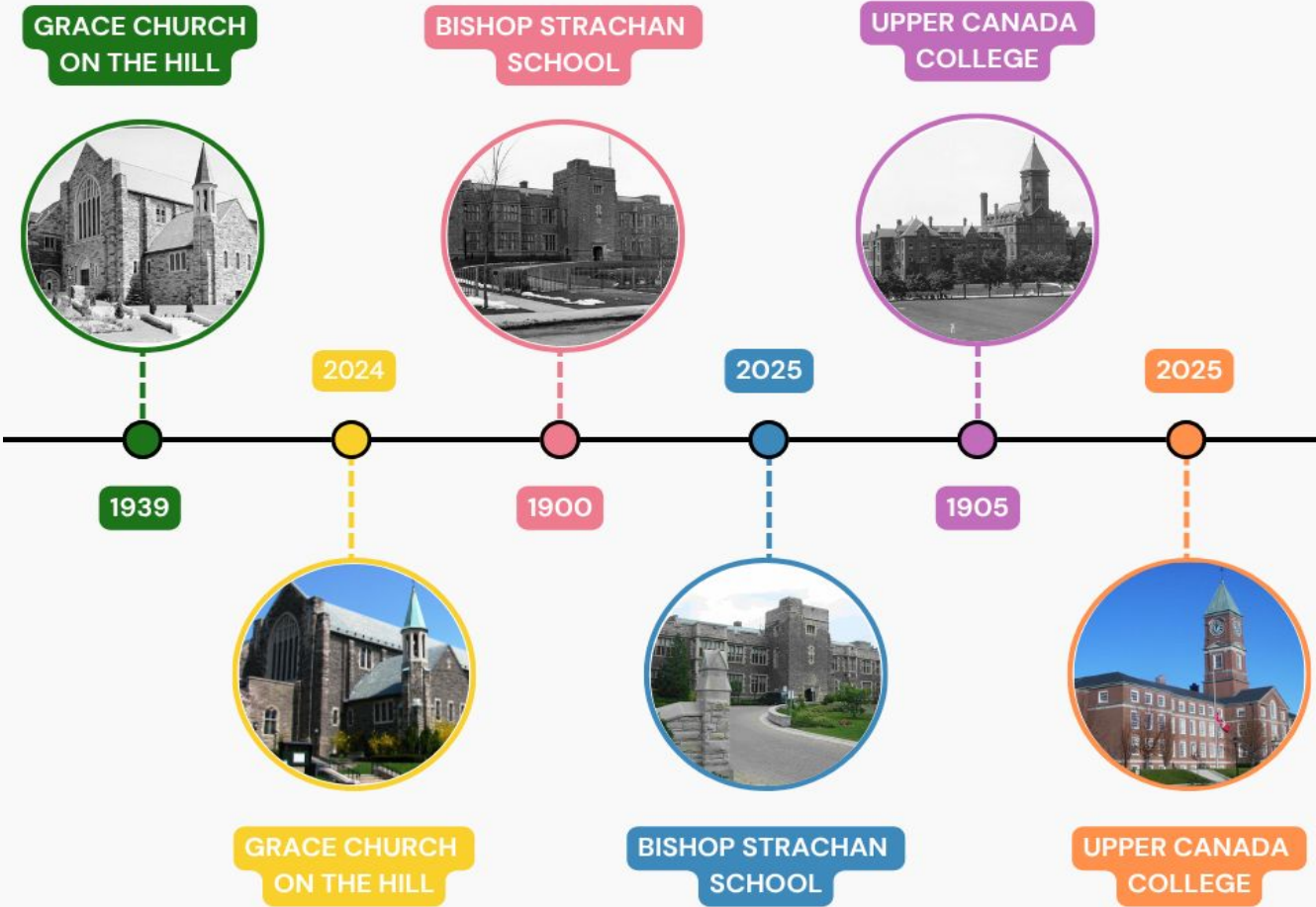


32 Eglinton West



ELEMENT 4: SOCIAL & COMMUNITY SERVICES

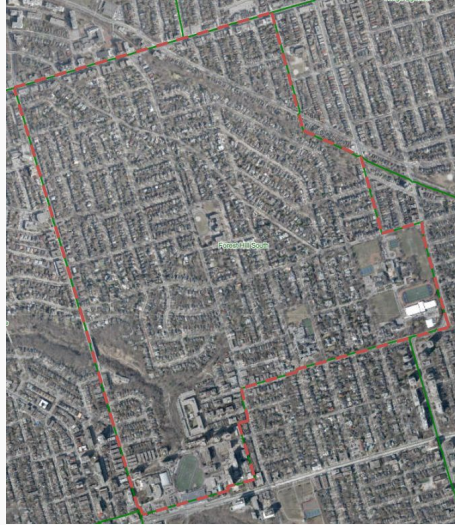
Forest Hill South was shaped by elite institutions like *Bishop Strachan School*, *Upper Canada College*, and *Grace Church on-the-Hill*, reflecting values of wealth, tradition, and exclusivity. Early planning lacked public community services, reinforcing a socially closed identity. Today, the area remains affluent but is gradually becoming more inclusive, with broader access to schools and public amenities.



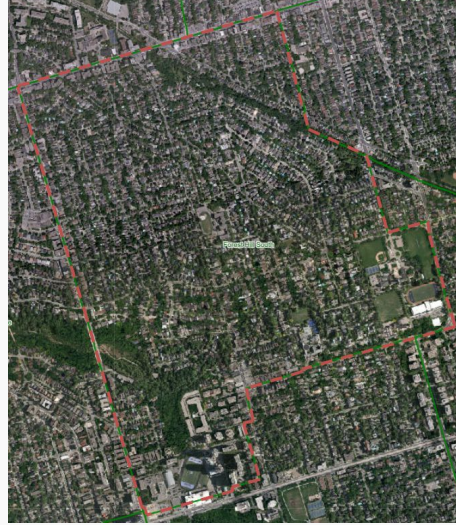
OVER TIME: AERIAL & MAP COMPARISON



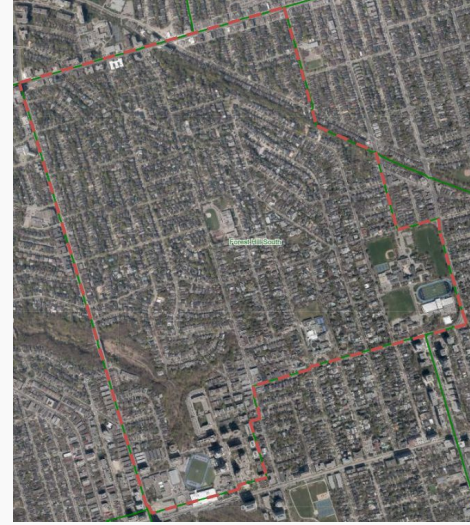
Forest Hill South – 1965 Form



Forest Hill South – 2009 Form



Forest Hill South – 2014 Form



Forest Hill South – 2023 Form

Observations:

- Residential core largely unchanged in lot pattern and density.
- Commercial edges and arterial corridors show increased built-form intensity.
- Transit infrastructure (bus corridors, LRT planning) influences development along Eglinton.

Change drivers: Market demand, municipal intensification policy, transit investments, community/heritage protection.

The aerial photographs from 1965 and 2023 illustrate decades of gradual urban evolution in Forest Hill South.

Despite major development pressures across Toronto, this neighbourhood's landscape and built form have remained remarkably consistent, revealing strong planning control and community resistance to high-density change.

FINDINGS: WHICH ELEMENTS CHANGED AND WHY?

PERIOD	KEY CHANGE	LIKELY CAUSE
1939–1954	Minimal land-use change; low-density pattern persists	Strong private zoning covenants; elite exclusivity
1950s–1970s	Addition of private schools and religious institutions	Demographic growth; suburban identity
1980s–2000s	Small apartment & condominium infill near arterial roads	Municipal up-zoning & real-estate pressure
2010s–2020s	Mixed-use intensification along Eglinton & Bathurst	Transit-oriented development (Eglinton Crosstown LRT) and urban densification policies

THEME	EARLY 20TH CENTURY VALUE	2021 EVOLUTION
Land exclusivity	Large lots, controlled zoning for affluent residents	Heritage protection; resistance to high-rise development
Community design	Self-contained “village” identity	Ongoing pride in small commercial core
Nature & aesthetics	Garden suburb ideals; tree-lined streets	Mature tree canopy, conservation focus
Economic function	Residential enclave, not employment node	Slowly diversifying via local retail & professional services

THE SEVEN GRANDFATHER TEACHINGS

The Seven Grandfather Teachings are set of Anishinaabe guiding principles that give people the tools for how to live a good life. They have been passed down from generation to generation for thousands of years through stories and ceremonies. These are fundamental virtues for a good life, **Wisdom, Love, Respect, Courage, Honesty, Humility, and Truth** symbolized with special animal trait and character that needed in order for communities to survive.

Eagle – Love



To be at peace with yourself and able to express love to your family, friends and community through your actions and words. To care deeply for oneself, others, and creation unconditionally.

Buffalo – Respect



The buffalo represents Respect because for as long as we have been here, we have sustained our lives through the Buffalo in terms of clothing, food, shelter, medicine and art.

Bear – Courage



It takes courage to do what is right. Courage is being brave in the face of life's problems. Daily challenges take courage to overcome. Never give in, never give up.

Sabe – Honesty



To be truthful and transparent in all actions and words. Never lie, cheat, steal or gossip. Be honest with yourself and others. Speak from your heart. Be true to your word.

Beaver – Wisdom



Show wisdom by using your gift and talent. Wisdom is gained through experience and knowledge. To have wisdom is to know the difference between right and wrong and to apply these qualities to your daily life.

Wolf – Humility



Think of others before yourself. Humility is to live your life free from arrogance, to not be boastful, and to have a modest sense of your own worth.

Turtle – Truth

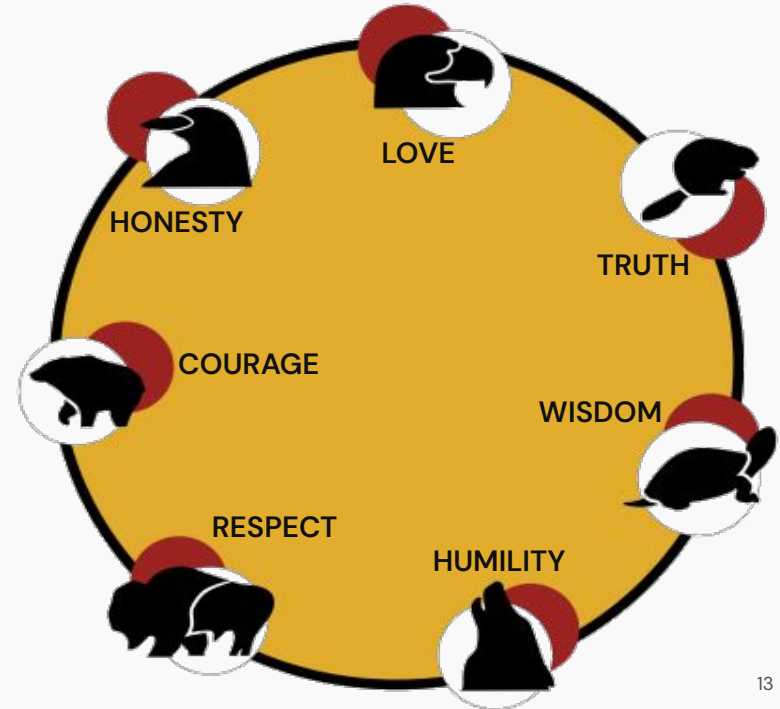


Always seek truth. Living the truth is living the Seven Teachings. To live by all these teachings and be true to oneself and others.

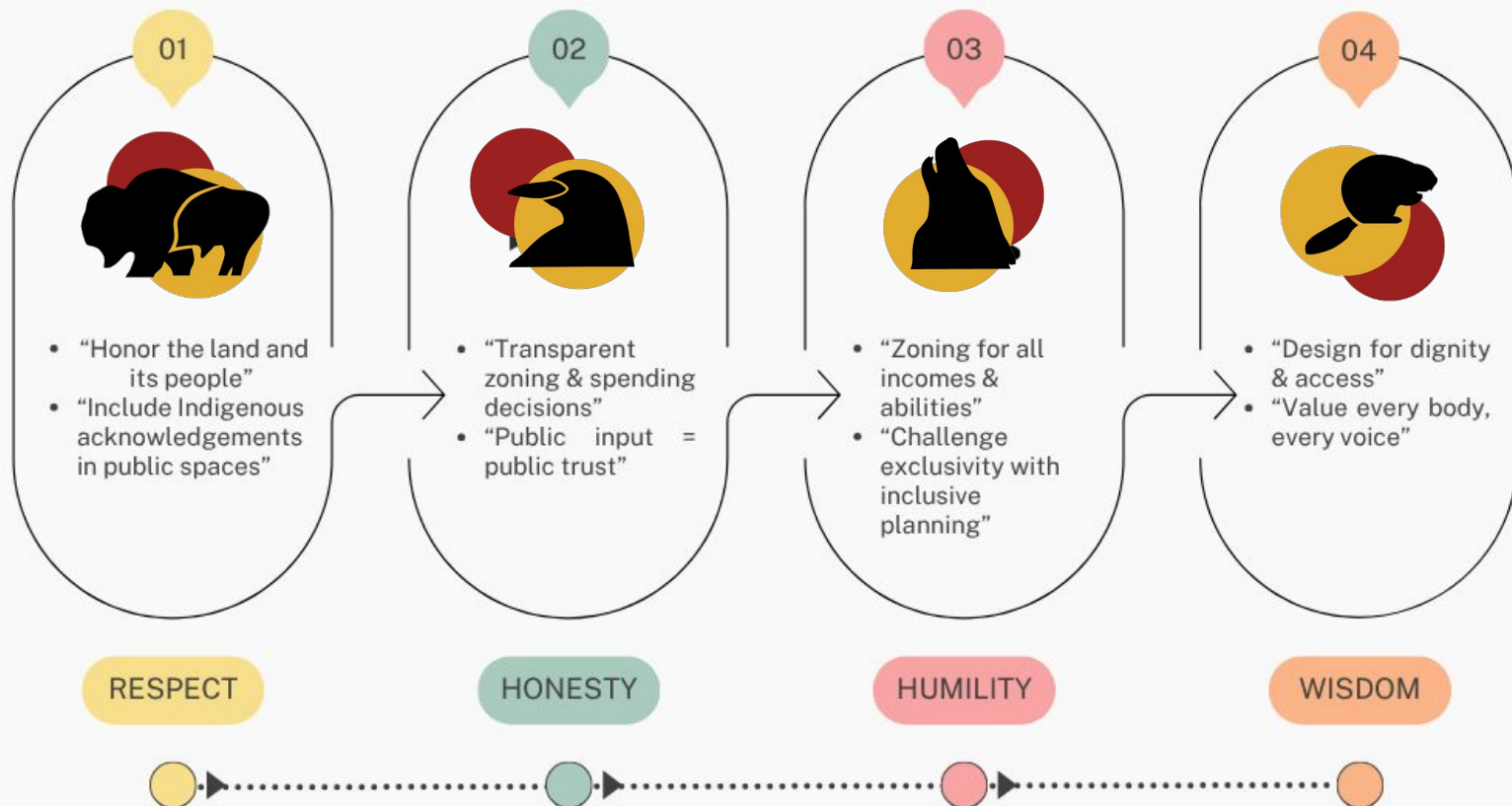
COMPARE & CONTRAST: ORIGINAL PLANNING VALUES VS. FOUR SELECTED TEACHINGS

Forest Hill was intentionally developed as an elite residential enclave, prioritizing an upscale quality of life for its residents. The original planning values of Forest Hill neighborhood were rooted in exclusivity, private control, and aesthetic uniformity for a privileged group, whereas the Seven Grandfather Teachings advocate for an inclusive, holistic, and respectful relationship with all people and the natural world. Looking into four of the grandfather teachings principles in relation to the original planning of Forest Hill neighborhood.

- **Respect:** Forest Hill prioritized exclusivity, favoring wealthy residents and excluding others. This contrasts with Respect, which honors all people and creation equally.
- **Honesty:** Forest Hill's identity was shaped by status and appearance. Honesty values authenticity and self-acceptance over aspirational emulation.
- **Humility:** Planning decisions reflected control and superiority, limiting diversity and industrial uses. Humility embraces equality and interconnectedness across all people and places.
- **Wisdom:** The neighbourhood was built with durable, high-quality design but mainly for its own benefit. True Wisdom calls for sustainable planning that serves the broader community and environment.



VISION: HOW FOUR TEACHINGS COULD SHAPE THE NEXT 30 YEARS



GROUP CONTRIBUTIONS & REFERENCES

Member	Topics Covered		
Nayra Robleto	Slide: Introduction,23,8,10,12	Map Creation, Layout, Data Collection	Formatting, Research
Vivek Khanna	Slide: 1,4,5,6,9,11	Layout, Image creation, Data Collection	Formatting, Research
Samuel Wiafe Akenten	Slide: 10,11	Data Collection	Research

Key References:

- City of Toronto. *Neighbourhood Profile – Forest Hill South (101)*, 2021.
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